

What else to watch: *The Gold Rush* (1925) ■ *The General* (1926) ■ *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *Modern Times* (1936) ■ *A Patch of Blue* (1965) ■ *Chaplin* (1992) ■ *The Artist* (2011)

kindness for the Tramp, who is now dressed in shabby clothes, the girl picks up the flower that has been knocked from his grasp by street kids, and as their hands touch, she suddenly recognizes him—so very different from the debonair prince she may have imagined. The Tramp looks anxiously into the eyes of the once-blind flower girl and asks, “You can see now?” “Yes,” she replies, “I can see now.”

This poignant exchange is one of the most famous dialogues in movie history—all the more telling because it comes from the silent era—and in many ways it is emblematic of the entire movie. It is not just the Tramp that the girl is seeing for the first time, but the truth, and the audience must see it too. In the noisy, brightly flashing world of the modern city, the little people, the downtrodden, and the lonely are forgotten and brushed aside. It is only through the purity of silence, simplicity, and blindness that people can regain their senses and learn to see clearly again.

Hope of tomorrow

The movie has a conservative and sentimental—some might even say mawkish—message, but there's no doubt that it touched a chord on its release, just two years after the Wall Street Crash. Times were troubled for countless millions, the poor in the US were beginning to feel the pinch of the Great Depression, and suicides

struck both the rich and the poor as the crisis deepened. While the movie offered no recipes for recovery, what it did, cleverly, was to provide a glimmer of hope. After rescuing the millionaire from suicide in the river, the Tramp urges him to be hopeful. “Tomorrow the birds will sing,” he says. No matter how bleak things look today, people must cling to the idea that there may be joy tomorrow—that seems to be the core of the movie's message.

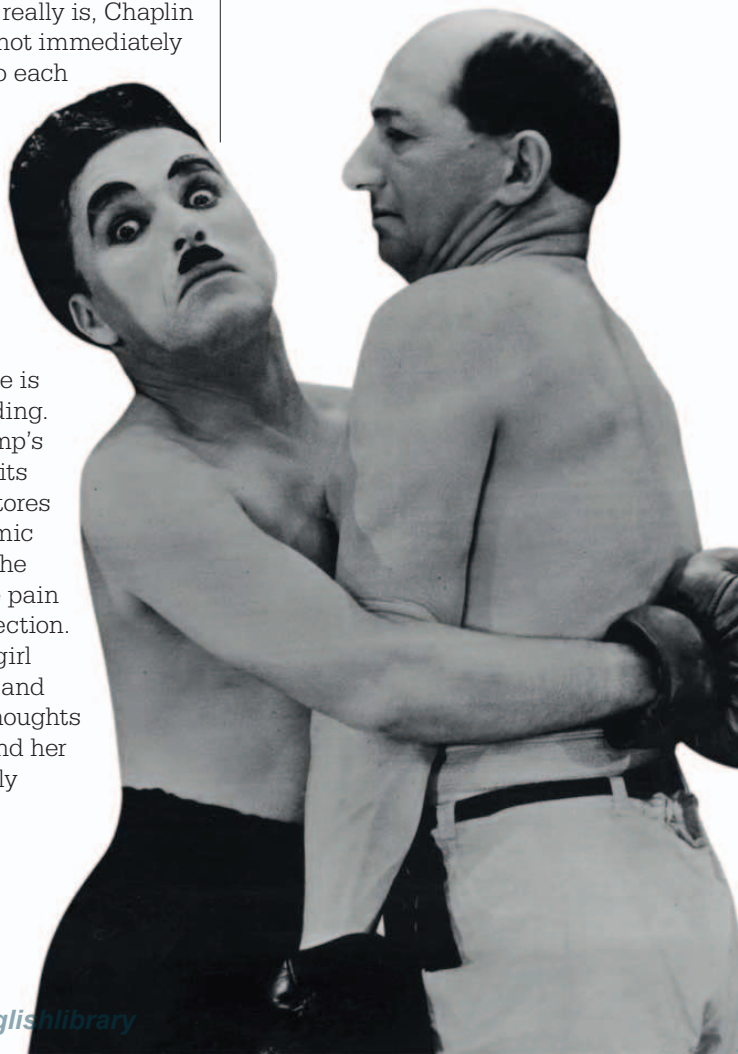
Happy ending?

When the flower girl finally sees the Tramp for who he really is, Chaplin the director does not immediately have them fall into each other's arms in recognition. We do not know if the flower girl will embrace or reject him because he is so different from the man of her imagination. There is no neat happy ending.

While the Tramp's winsome look elicits pathos, it also restores the movie to a comic level, distancing the audience from the pain of his possible rejection. But as the flower girl looks back at him and viewers see the thoughts turning over behind her eyes and the faintly

fluttering flares of hope, that's enough. It's not clear what that hope is—that she will find her true happiness with such a bedraggled man, or that they will both walk away, wiser but content. All that matters is that there is hope, the hope inspired by the thought that the birds will sing tomorrow, come what may. ■

The boxing scene, in which the Tramp spends most of his time hiding behind the referee or running from his opponent to avoid combat, shows off Chaplin's clowning skills.



“I’m cured. You’re my friend for life.”

The millionaire / City Lights